

TYPES OF DINOSAURS

Dinosaurs first evolved around 245 million years ago, and spent the next several million years in the shadow of other land-living animals. It was only in the Late Triassic Period, about 225 million years ago, that dinosaurs began evolving into many different groups. In these early years, dinosaurs represented only a fraction of the animal population but gradually came to dominate nearly all land-based ecosystems. Scientists think that dinosaurs might have flourished due to changes in the climate that may have contributed to the extinction of competitors. Dinosaurs are broadly divided into two main types, the saurischians and the ornithischians, which are each further divided into several diverse groups. However, some scientists have proposed the existence of another group, the Ornithoscelida, which is composed of theropods and ornithischians.

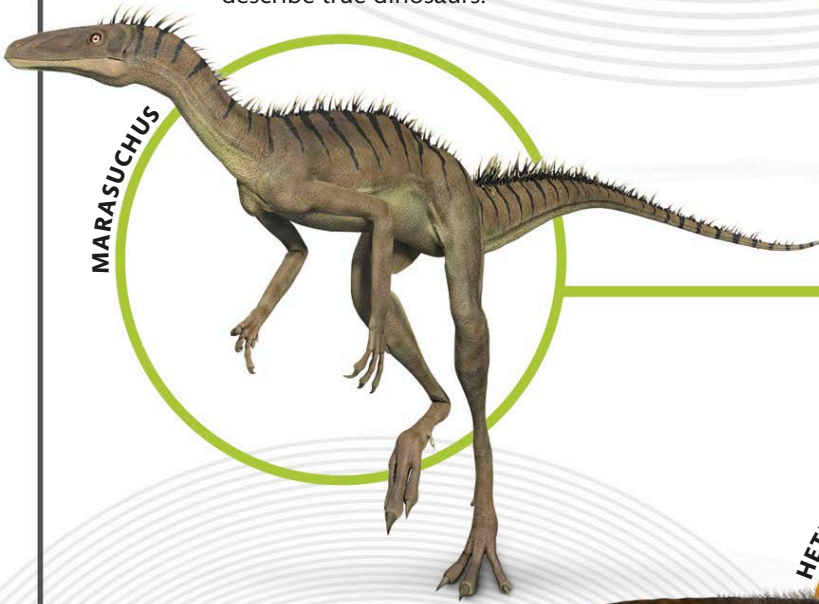
EARLY RELATIVES

Dinosaurs evolved from a group of reptiles called the dinosauriforms. Many of these creatures were small and fed on insects, and they shared some of the characteristics used to describe true dinosaurs.

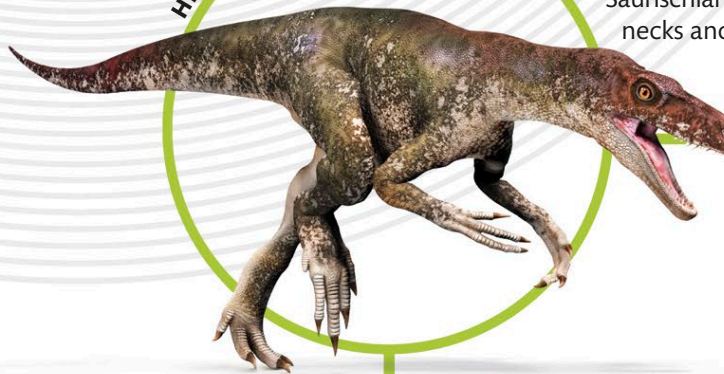
SAURISCHIANS

These dinosaurs are defined by the shape of their hips, which resembled those of modern-day lizards. Saurischians tended to have long necks and large thumb claws.

MARASUCHUS



HERRERASAURUS



HETERODONTOSAURUS



ORNITHISCHIANS

Although ornithischians are not the ancestors of birds, their hip bones were similar to those of modern-day birds. They also had an extra bone on their lower jaw that supported a strong beak.